

The Forge Wars: Embers of Rebellion

A D&D 5th Edition Campaign Adventure (1 of 3)

For Characters Level 1-4

Adventure Length: 5-6 sessions

Party Size: 4-6 characters

Adventure Type: Investigation / Social Intrigue / Light Combat

Themes: Industrial oppression, worker's rights, emerging threats, the cost of progress

Campaign Overview: The Forge Wars

The Forge Wars is a three-part campaign that begins with industrial unrest and builds to an epic confrontation with fire giant overlords who have been secretly manipulating mortal civilizations for their own ends.

Campaign Timeline:

1. **Embers of Rebellion** (Levels 1-4): Industrial mystery and worker uprising
 2. **Flames of Conspiracy** (Levels 4-7): Political intrigue and ancient secrets
 3. **Inferno of the Titans** (Levels 7-10): Direct confrontation with fire giant lords
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Adventure Background

The industrial city of Ironhaven has prospered for decades under the leadership of the Forgemaster's Guild, whose advanced metalworking techniques have made them wealthy and powerful. However, beneath the surface prosperity, tensions simmer between the guild masters and the common workers who toil in dangerous conditions for meager wages.

Recently, those tensions have exploded into open conflict. Workers are organizing strikes and protests, citing not only poor working conditions but also strange incidents in the deepest forges - unexplained accidents, workers disappearing, and reports of "voices in the flames" giving impossible orders. The guild masters dismiss these claims as superstition and rabble-rousing, but the workers believe something sinister lurks in the heart of Ironhaven's industrial empire.

The Hidden Truth: Unknown to both workers and most guild members, Ironhaven's prosperity comes from a secret pact made fifty years ago between the guild's founder and Thane Embercrown, a powerful fire giant lord. In exchange for advanced metalworking knowledge and magical enhancements to their forges, the guild has been secretly providing the fire giants with specially crafted weapons and intelligence about the surface world's military capabilities.

The Current Crisis: Thane Embercrown's plans are entering a new phase. He needs more than just weapons - he requires a significant number of skilled smiths and magical artificers to be brought to his stronghold in the Elemental Plane of Fire. The recent "accidents" and disappearances are actually kidnappings, with the most skilled workers being secretly transported through hidden portals in the deepest forges.

The Workers' Perspective: The common smiths and laborers have no knowledge of the fire giant connection, but they can sense that something is fundamentally wrong. Their protests and strikes are genuine expressions of frustration with their treatment, but they're also unconsciously responding to the supernatural evil that has infected their workplace.

The City of Ironhaven

Overview

Ironhaven sits at the confluence of three major trade rivers, surrounded by rich iron deposits and coal mines. The city's skyline is dominated by massive smokestacks and the towering spires of the Grand Forge, the guild's primary manufacturing complex.

Population: 15,000 people

- **Guild Masters and Wealthy Merchants:** 500 people (3%)
- **Skilled Artisans and Middle Class:** 2,500 people (17%)
- **Common Workers and Laborers:** 12,000 people (80%)

City Districts

The Heights - *Where the powerful live*

- Luxurious mansions of guild masters and successful merchants
- The Guild Hall: ornate headquarters of the Forgemaster's Guild
- Exclusive shops and restaurants catering to the wealthy
- Private guards and magical protections

The Foundry Quarter - *The industrial heart*

- The Grand Forge: massive complex of interconnected foundries and workshops
- Smaller specialized smithies and metalworking shops
- Warehouses storing raw materials and finished goods
- The Guild Barracks: housing for guild enforcers

The Commons - *Where most people live*

- Modest homes and apartment buildings for skilled workers
- The Market Square: central hub for commerce and gatherings
- Taverns, inns, and shops serving the working population
- The Worker's Hall: unofficial gathering place for labor organizers

The Soot Districts - *Home to the poorest workers*

- Crowded tenements housing unskilled laborers
- Dangerous, poorly maintained buildings

- Black market traders and illegal activities
- The Smoke: notorious tavern where grievances are aired

The Docks - *Gateway to the outside world*

- River ports handling raw materials and finished goods
- Warehouses controlled by various trading companies
- Transient population of sailors, merchants, and travelers
- Information hub for news from other cities

Recent Tensions

Worker Grievances:

- Fourteen-hour work days in dangerous conditions
- Wages that barely cover basic necessities
- Guild masters living in luxury while workers struggle
- Recent increase in workplace "accidents" and mysterious disappearances
- Demands for basic safety measures being ignored

Guild Response:

- Dismissing worker concerns as laziness and ingratitude
- Hiring additional guards to "maintain order"
- Threatening to replace local workers with imported labor
- Claiming that economic pressures require current working conditions
- Secret panic about maintaining their supernatural arrangements

External Pressures:

- Competing cities offering better trade terms
- Political pressure from regional lords concerned about unrest
- Mysterious orders for weapons from unknown buyers
- Strange magical phenomena affecting the forges
- Rumors of similar problems in other industrial cities

Adventure Hooks

The Concerned Relative

A party member has family working in Ironhaven's foundries. Recent letters have stopped coming, and the last message mentioned "strange happenings" and growing fear among the workers. The relative specifically asked for help, saying they don't trust local authorities.

The Guild Commission

The Forgemaster's Guild hires the party as "neutral investigators" to look into the worker unrest and determine the truth behind claims of supernatural incidents. They offer good pay but seem more interested in discrediting the workers than finding genuine solutions.

The Worker's Plea

Representatives of the workers secretly approach the party, asking for help investigating disappearances and strange incidents that the guild refuses to acknowledge. They can't pay much, but they offer information and the support of the common people.

The Merchant's Investment

A wealthy merchant from another city has invested heavily in Ironhaven's industries and is concerned about reports of instability. They hire the party to assess the situation and protect their interests, giving them cover to investigate freely.

The Magical Anomaly

A wizard's college or magical organization has detected unusual magical emanations from Ironhaven and sends the party to investigate. They suspect illegal magical experimentation or planar breaches.

Act I: Trouble in the Foundries

Scene 1: Arrival in the City

Setting: The party arrives in Ironhaven during a tense moment. Smoke from the foundries creates a perpetual haze over the city, and the air rings with the sound of hammers on anvils. However, there's an underlying tension - fewer workers than usual on the streets, groups of armed guards patrolling, and hushed conversations that stop when strangers approach.

Initial Impressions:

- **The Wealth Gap:** Stark contrast between the luxurious Heights and the squalid Soot Districts
- **Industrial Scale:** The Grand Forge complex is massive and impressive, but also intimidating
- **Nervous Energy:** People seem on edge, with workers eyeing guild guards suspiciously
- **Strange Sounds:** Occasional rumbles and flashes of light from the deepest foundries

First Encounters:

- **Street Argument:** Witnesses to a heated confrontation between workers and guild guards
- **Propaganda:** Guild proclamations posted throughout the city dismissing worker concerns
- **Whispered Warnings:** Common people quietly advising the party to be careful whom they trust
- **Economic Impact:** Shopkeepers complaining about reduced business due to the unrest

Scene 2: The Mysterious Accident

Setting: The party witnesses or investigates a "workplace accident" at one of the smaller foundries. A worker named Marcus Ironhand was severely burned in what officials claim was carelessness with molten metal, but witnesses suggest something more sinister.

The Official Story:

- Marcus was working alone on a routine casting job
- He allegedly fell asleep and knocked over a crucible of molten iron
- Guild supervisors claim he'd been drinking and was negligent
- The incident is being used to justify stricter workplace rules

The Workers' Version:

- Marcus was one of the most experienced and careful smiths in the foundry

- He'd been investigating strange sounds and lights in the deep forges
- Just before the accident, he told friends he'd discovered something important
- Several workers report hearing inhuman voices giving orders that night

Investigation Opportunities:

- **Medical Examination:** Marcus's burns show an unusual pattern inconsistent with a simple spill
- **Witness Interviews:** Workers provide conflicting accounts under pressure from guild oversight
- **Scene Analysis:** The foundry shows signs of struggle and magical interference
- **Personal Effects:** Marcus's tools and notes contain cryptic references to "fire that speaks"

Key Clues:

- Magical residue suggesting planar magic was used
- Scorch marks in patterns that resemble giant runes
- A hidden note from Marcus mentioning "the deep forges hide the truth"
- Tools that show signs of being enhanced with fire magic

Scene 3: The Workers' Meeting

Setting: The party is invited (secretly) to attend a clandestine meeting of worker organizers in the basement of The Copper Mug tavern. Here they meet the leaders of the growing resistance movement and learn about the broader pattern of problems.

Key NPCs Introduced:

- **Elena Steelheart:** Charismatic leader of the worker's movement
- **Old Henrik:** Former foreman who knows the foundries' history
- **Sara Brightforge:** Young artificer who's noticed magical anomalies
- **Tom Coalbeard:** Miner who's seen strange things in the deepest shafts

Information Revealed:

- **Pattern of Disappearances:** Seventeen skilled workers have vanished over the past six months

- **Supernatural Incidents:** Reports of voices speaking Giant, flames that burn cold, and tools that move by themselves
- **Guild Secrecy:** Increased security around the deepest levels of the Grand Forge
- **Economic Pressure:** The guild is pushing workers harder while cutting safety measures
- **Outside Connections:** Mysterious buyers placing large orders for weapons and armor

The Workers' Requests:

- Investigate the disappearances without alerting the guild
- Discover what's really happening in the deep forges
- Help them gather evidence of guild wrongdoing
- Protect organizers from guild retaliation

Complication: Guild informants may be present at the meeting, requiring careful social maneuvering to avoid exposing worker sympathizers.

Act II: The Workers' Uprising

Scene 4: Gathering Evidence

Setting: The party begins investigating the guild's activities while navigating the complex social dynamics between workers and management.

Investigation Paths:

Official Channels: Working with guild cooperation

- Access to official records and facilities
- Guild escorts who may hide or distort evidence
- Pressure to reach conclusions favorable to management
- Risk of being manipulated or misled

Underground Network: Working with the workers

- Access to personal testimonies and hidden evidence

- Risk of being caught and labeled as agitators
- Limited resources but genuine commitment to truth
- Danger from guild retaliation

Independent Investigation: Trying to remain neutral

- Freedom to pursue all leads without bias
- Difficulty gaining trust from either side
- Need to carefully balance conflicting interests
- Risk of being seen as threat by both factions

Key Evidence to Discover:

- **Financial Records:** Large payments to unknown recipients
- **Worker Testimonies:** Detailed accounts of supernatural incidents
- **Physical Evidence:** Magical residue and strange materials in the forges
- **Historical Context:** Changes in guild practices over the past fifty years

Scene 5: The Strike Begins

Setting: Tensions finally boil over when news spreads that another worker, Elena's brother Jakob, has disappeared. The workers organize a massive strike that shuts down production throughout the city.

The Strike Event:

- **Worker Demands:** Safe working conditions, investigation of disappearances, and recognition of their organizing rights
- **Guild Response:** Hiring mercenaries and threatening to bring in replacement workers
- **City Reaction:** Citizens split between supporting workers and fearing economic disruption
- **Political Pressure:** Regional authorities demand quick resolution

Party Challenges:

- **Choosing Sides:** Pressure to openly support either workers or guild

- **Maintaining Access:** Risk of losing cooperation from whichever side they don't support
- **Preventing Violence:** Both sides are arming and preparing for confrontation
- **Gathering Information:** Using the chaos to investigate restricted areas

Escalating Events:

- **Day 1:** Peaceful work stoppage and organized demonstrations
- **Day 2:** Guild brings in mercenaries, tensions rise
- **Day 3:** First violent clashes between workers and guild forces
- **Day 4:** Party must choose how to intervene before full civil conflict erupts

Scene 6: Infiltrating the Deep Forges

Setting: Using the strike as cover, the party attempts to investigate the deepest levels of the Grand Forge where the most mysterious incidents have occurred.

Security Challenges:

- **Magical Wards:** Protective spells that detect intruders
- **Guard Patrols:** Both human guards and mechanical constructs
- **Environmental Hazards:** Extreme heat, toxic fumes, and unstable machinery
- **Supernatural Guardians:** Creatures bound to protect guild secrets

What They Discover:

- **Portal Chamber:** A hidden chamber containing an active portal to the Elemental Plane of Fire
- **Giant Runes:** Massive runic inscriptions that facilitate communication with fire giants
- **Prisoner Holding:** A magical prison where kidnapped workers are kept before transport
- **Weapons Cache:** Specially crafted weapons designed for giant-sized hands
- **Communication Records:** Messages between guild leaders and fire giant lords

The Horrifying Truth: The missing workers have been taken through the portal to serve as slaves in fire giant forges. The guild has been complicit in this kidnapping operation in exchange for magical knowledge and enhanced manufacturing capabilities.

Act III: The Hidden Truth

Scene 7: Confronting the Guild Master

Setting: Armed with evidence of the guild's supernatural bargain, the party must decide how to confront Guildmaster Thorne Ironbeard, the man responsible for the original pact with the fire giants.

Guildmaster Thorne's Position:

- **Justification:** Claims the arrangement has brought prosperity to the entire city
- **Necessity:** Argues that without fire giant knowledge, Ironhaven would fail economically
- **Sacrifice:** Believes the loss of a few workers is acceptable for the greater good
- **Desperation:** Knows that breaking the pact would bring fire giant retaliation

Confrontation Options:

- **Legal Approach:** Using evidence to expose the guild through official channels
- **Direct Confrontation:** Demanding immediate cessation of the kidnapping operation
- **Negotiation:** Attempting to find an alternative solution that satisfies all parties
- **Covert Action:** Working to sabotage the operation without direct confrontation

Thorne's Revelations:

- The fire giants are preparing for a larger operation against surface cities
- Ironhaven is just one of several cities that have made similar pacts
- The weapons being produced are intended for an army of giant-kin and their allies
- Breaking the pact now would make Ironhaven a target for immediate retaliation

Scene 8: The Portal Crisis

Setting: As the party's investigation reaches its climax, the fire giants accelerate their timeline. A large contingent of fire giant warriors begins emerging through the portal to secure their operation and eliminate potential threats.

The Immediate Threat:

- **Fire Giant Assault:** 2-3 fire giants emerge to secure the portal chamber
- **Guild Betrayal:** Some guild members realize they've been used and turn against their former allies
- **Worker Rescue:** Several kidnapped workers are still alive and can be saved
- **Portal Stability:** The magical portal begins showing signs of instability

Combat Challenges:

- **Fire Giants:** Too powerful for direct combat, requiring creative solutions
- **Environmental Hazards:** Fighting in an active forge with lava flows and extreme heat
- **Innocent Bystanders:** Protecting workers and reformed guild members
- **Time Pressure:** The portal must be closed before more giants arrive

Resolution Options:

- **Sabotage:** Destroying the portal mechanism to cut off fire giant reinforcements
- **Bargaining:** Negotiating with the fire giants for safe passage and worker release
- **Magical Solution:** Using spells or artifacts to banish the giants or close the portal
- **Heroic Sacrifice:** Someone staying behind to ensure others escape safely

Scene 9: The New Order

Setting: With the immediate crisis resolved, the party must help Ironhaven establish a new social and economic order while preparing for the larger threats revealed by their investigation.

Immediate Consequences:

- **Guild Restructuring:** The Forgemaster's Guild must be reformed or replaced
- **Worker Empowerment:** The common people have proven their worth and demand representation

- **Economic Transition:** The city must find new sources of prosperity without fire giant assistance
- **Defense Preparation:** Knowledge of the broader fire giant threat requires military preparation

Long-term Implications:

- **Regional Warning:** Other cities must be warned about potential fire giant infiltration
- **Political Changes:** The power structure in Ironhaven fundamentally shifts
- **Technological Loss:** Some advanced techniques may be lost without fire giant knowledge
- **Ongoing Threat:** The fire giants will not forget this setback and will seek revenge

Party's Role in Resolution:

- **Advisors:** Helping establish new governmental and economic structures
- **Investigators:** Gathering intelligence about fire giant activities in other cities
- **Diplomats:** Representing Ironhaven's interests to regional authorities
- **Heroes:** Being recognized as the saviors who exposed the conspiracy

Key Locations

1. The Grand Forge

The massive industrial complex that serves as the heart of Ironhaven's economy and the center of the conspiracy.

Public Areas:

- **Reception Hall:** Impressive entrance designed to impress visitors and clients
- **Administrative Offices:** Where guild business is conducted and records are kept
- **Showroom Forges:** Demonstrations of basic metalworking for tours and inspections
- **Warehouse Districts:** Storage for raw materials and finished goods

Restricted Areas:

- **Master Forges:** High-security workshops where the finest work is done
- **Guild Sanctum:** Private meeting chambers for guild leadership
- **Deep Foundries:** The lowest levels where the most dangerous work occurs
- **Portal Chamber:** Hidden room containing the gateway to the Elemental Plane of Fire

Environmental Features:

- **Extreme Heat:** Constitution saves required in deeper areas
- **Magical Enhancement:** Tools and forges enhanced with fire giant magic
- **Security Systems:** Both mundane and magical protections
- **Industrial Hazards:** Moving machinery, molten metal, and toxic fumes

2. The Worker's Hall

An unofficial gathering place in the Commons where workers organize and share information.

Main Floor:

- **Common Room:** Large space for meetings and social gatherings
- **Message Board:** Where workers post information about jobs, grievances, and news
- **Kitchen:** Community space for shared meals and informal discussions
- **Small Library:** Collection of technical manuals and labor organizing literature

Hidden Areas:

- **Secret Meeting Room:** Concealed basement chamber for sensitive discussions
- **Weapons Cache:** Small collection of improvised weapons for self-defense
- **Escape Tunnels:** Hidden passages connecting to other buildings in the Commons
- **Information Archive:** Documents and evidence gathered about guild activities

3. The Heights District

Luxurious area where guild masters live, revealing the stark wealth inequality in the city.

Notable Locations:

- **Ironbeard Mansion:** Guildmaster Thorne's opulent residence

- **Guild Masters' Club:** Exclusive social club for the wealthy elite
- **Luxury Markets:** High-end shops selling imported goods and magical items
- **Private Gardens:** Beautiful landscaped areas contrasting with the industrial city

Security Features:

- **Private Guards:** Well-equipped mercenaries protecting the wealthy
- **Magical Protections:** Wards and alarms on important buildings
- **Exclusive Access:** Checkpoints limiting who can enter the district
- **Information Control:** Servants and staff carefully monitored for loyalty

4. The Soot Districts

Overcrowded and dangerous neighborhoods where the poorest workers struggle to survive.

Living Conditions:

- **Tenement Buildings:** Overcrowded, poorly maintained apartment blocks
- **Communal Facilities:** Shared kitchens, bathrooms, and washing areas
- **Street Markets:** Informal economy selling basic necessities
- **Underground Economy:** Black market activities and illegal services

Social Dynamics:

- **Community Solidarity:** Strong bonds between residents facing similar hardships
- **Desperation:** Some residents willing to take dangerous risks for money
- **Information Network:** Residents often know more about city affairs than authorities realize
- **Hidden Talents:** Skilled workers living in poverty due to guild policies

NPCs and Factions

The Forgemaster's Guild

Guildmaster Thorne Ironbeard *Male dwarf, age 180, lawful evil* The current leader of the guild who inherited the fire giant pact from his predecessor.

- **Armor Class** 16 (Chain Mail, Shield)

- **Hit Points** 58 (9d8 + 18)
- **Speed** 25 ft.
- **STR** 16 (+3) **DEX** 12 (+1) **CON** 15 (+2) **INT** 14 (+2) **WIS** 13 (+1) **CHA** 16 (+3)
- **Skills** Intimidation +6, Persuasion +6
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 11
- **Languages** Common, Dwarvish, Giant
- **Challenge** 3 (700 XP)

Dwarven Resilience. Thorne has advantage on saving throws against poison and resistance to poison damage.

Leadership. Thorne can use a bonus action to target one ally within 30 feet. The target gains advantage on their next attack roll or saving throw.

Actions Multiattack. Thorne makes two weapon attacks.

Warhammer. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) bludgeoning damage, or 8 (1d10 + 3) bludgeoning damage if used with two hands.

Fire Giant's Blessing (1/Day). Thorne channels fire giant magic. His weapon attacks deal an additional 7 (2d6) fire damage for 1 minute.

Personality: Authoritarian, believes strongly in hierarchy and order **Goals:** Maintain the guild's power and prosperity at any cost **Secret:** Deeply regrets the pact but sees no way out without destroying the city **Roleplaying:** Speaks with authority but shows signs of stress and guilt

Master Forge-Wright Helena Goldstrike *Female human, age 45, neutral evil* Thorne's lieutenant who handles the day-to-day operations of the conspiracy.

Personality: Coldly pragmatic, sees people as resources to be managed **Goals:** Advance her position within the guild hierarchy **Role:** Coordinates the kidnapping operations and portal maintenance **Secret:** Has been skimming profits from the fire giant arrangement

The Workers' Movement

Elena Steelheart *Female human, age 28, chaotic good* Charismatic leader of the workers' uprising who became involved after her brother's disappearance.

- **Armor Class** 13 (Leather Armor)
- **Hit Points** 32 (5d8 + 10)
- **Speed** 30 ft.
- **STR** 14 (+2) **DEX** 16 (+3) **CON** 14 (+2) **INT** 13 (+1) **WIS** 15 (+2) **CHA** 17 (+3)
- **Skills** Insight +5, Persuasion +6, Sleight of Hand +6
- **Senses** passive Perception 12
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **Challenge** 2 (450 XP)

Rally the Workers. As a bonus action, Elena can inspire allies within 30 feet. Affected allies gain advantage on their next attack roll or saving throw.

Sneak Attack. Once per turn, Elena can deal an extra 7 (2d6) damage when she hits with a weapon attack and has advantage on the attack roll.

Actions **Shortsword.** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

Light Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, range 80/320 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) piercing damage.

Personality: Passionate, inspiring, fiercely protective of fellow workers **Goals:** Improve working conditions and expose guild corruption **Background:** Former guild apprentice who left after witnessing safety violations **Roleplaying:** Speaks with conviction, quick to defend the downtrodden

Old Henrik *Male human, age 65, lawful good* Former foreman with deep knowledge of the guild's history and operations.

Personality: Wise, cautious, carries guilt about past complicity **Goals:** Make amends for years of silence about guild wrongdoing **Knowledge:** Remembers when the guild's practices began changing fifty years ago **Role:** Provides historical context and inside information about guild operations

Sara Brightforge *Female gnome, age 35, neutral good* Talented artificer who first noticed the magical anomalies in the forges.

Personality: Curious, methodical, struggles with the ethical implications of her discoveries

Goals: Understand the source of the magical enhancements and their true cost **Abilities:**

Can detect and analyze magical effects, understands enchanted items **Role:** Technical

expert who helps the party understand the fire giant magic

Fire Giant Agents

Forge-Thane Grimhammer *Huge giant, lawful evil* Fire giant lieutenant sent to oversee the final phase of the operation.

- **Armor Class** 18 (Plate)
- **Hit Points** 162 (13d12 + 78)
- **Speed** 30 ft.
- **STR** 25 (+7) **DEX** 9 (-1) **CON** 23 (+6) **INT** 10 (+0) **WIS** 14 (+2) **CHA** 13 (+1)
- **Saving Throws** Dex +5, Con +12, Cha +7
- **Skills** Athletics +13, Intimidation +7, Perception +8
- **Damage Immunities** fire
- **Senses** passive Perception 18
- **Languages** Giant, Common
- **Challenge** 9 (5,000 XP)

Actions **Multiattack.** The fire giant makes two greatsword attacks.

Greatsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +13 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* 28 (6d6 + 7) slashing damage.

Rock. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +13 to hit, range 60/240 ft., one target. *Hit:* 29 (4d10 + 7) bludgeoning damage.

Personality: Arrogant, views smaller races as inferior tools **Goals:** Complete the acquisition of skilled smiths for the fire giant forges **Tactics:** Prefers intimidation and overwhelming force to subtlety **Weakness:** Underestimates the capabilities of smaller races

City Authorities

Captain Marcus Steelwatch *Male human, age 40, lawful neutral* Head of the city guard who's caught between maintaining order and doing what's right.

Personality: Dutiful, conflicted, wants to serve justice but faces political pressure **Goals:** Maintain peace while investigating the truth **Dilemma:** Torn between supporting workers' legitimate grievances and preventing violence **Potential Ally:** Can be convinced to support the party with sufficient evidence

Encounters and Challenges

Investigation Encounters

Guild Headquarters Infiltration *Social and stealth challenge to access restricted guild records*

Challenge Rating: 2 (450 XP) **Skills Required:** Stealth, Deception, Investigation, Thieves' Tools **Obstacles:**

- Guard patrols (Perception DC 15 to avoid)
- Locked offices (Thieves' Tools DC 15)
- Magical wards (Arcana DC 13 to identify, Thieves' Tools DC 17 to bypass)
- Document analysis (Investigation DC 12 to find relevant information)

Success: Access to financial records showing payments to unknown recipients **Failure:** Alert raised, future investigations become more difficult

Worker Interview Network *Social challenge to gather testimony while avoiding guild informants*

Challenge Rating: 1 (200 XP) **Skills Required:** Insight, Persuasion, Investigation **Complications:**

- Identifying trustworthy workers (Insight DC 13)
- Convincing frightened witnesses to talk (Persuasion DC 15)
- Detecting guild informants (Insight DC 14)

- Piecing together conflicting accounts (Investigation DC 12)

Success: Detailed pattern of disappearances and supernatural incidents **Failure:** Information becomes compromised, witnesses face retaliation

Combat Encounters

Guild Enforcer Squad *When the party's investigation threatens guild interests*

Guild Enforcer (CR 1/2 each) *Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral*

- **Armor Class** 14 (Studded Leather, Shield)
- **Hit Points** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 30 ft.
- **STR** 13 (+1) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 12 (+1) **INT** 10 (+0) **WIS** 11 (+0) **CHA** 10 (+0)
- **Skills** Intimidation +2, Perception +2
- **Senses** passive Perception 12
- **Languages** Common
- **Challenge** 1/2 (100 XP)

Actions **Shortsword.** *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Light Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 80/320 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) piercing damage.

Encounter: 3-4 Guild Enforcers **Tactics:** Attempt to capture rather than kill, use intimidation and show of force **Resolution:** Can be convinced to stand down with successful Intimidation or Persuasion (DC 15)

Fire Elemental Guardian *Summoned creature protecting the portal chamber*

Fire Elemental *Large elemental, neutral*

- **Armor Class** 13
- **Hit Points** 102 (12d10 + 36)

- **Speed** 50 ft.
- **STR** 10 (+0) **DEX** 17 (+3) **CON** 16 (+3) **INT** 6 (-2) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 7 (-2)
- **Damage Resistances** bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
- **Damage Immunities** fire, poison
- **Condition Immunities** exhaustion, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained, unconscious
- **Senses** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Ignan
- **Challenge** 5 (1,800 XP)

Fire Form. The elemental can move through a space as narrow as 1 inch wide without squeezing. A creature that touches the elemental or hits it with a melee attack while within 5 feet of it takes 5 (1d10) fire damage. In addition, the elemental can enter a hostile creature's space and stop there. The first time it enters a creature's space on a turn, that creature takes 5 (1d10) fire damage and catches fire; until someone takes an action to douse the fire, the creature takes 5 (1d10) fire damage at the start of each of its turns.

Illumination. The elemental sheds bright light in a 30-foot radius and dim light in an additional 30 feet.

Water Susceptibility. For every 5 feet the elemental moves in water, or for every gallon of water splashed on it, it takes 1 cold damage.

Actions Multiattack. The elemental makes two touch attacks.

Touch. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (2d6 + 3) fire damage. If the target is a creature or a flammable object, it ignites. Until a creature takes an action to douse the fire, the target takes 5 (1d10) fire damage at the start of each of its turns.

Encounter: 1 Fire Elemental **Tactics:** Uses mobility and fire immunity to control the battlefield **Environment:** Forge setting provides cover but also fire hazards **Resolution:** Destroyed when portal is closed or can be banished with appropriate magic

Corrupted Forge Workers *Workers who have been magically influenced by prolonged exposure to fire giant magic*

Corrupted Worker (CR 1/4 each) *Medium humanoid (human), chaotic neutral*

- **Armor Class** 12 (Leather Armor)
- **Hit Points** 9 (2d8)
- **Speed** 30 ft.
- **STR** 15 (+2) **DEX** 13 (+1) **CON** 11 (+0) **INT** 8 (-1) **WIS** 9 (-1) **CHA** 7 (-2)
- **Damage Resistances** fire
- **Senses** passive Perception 9
- **Languages** Common, can understand Giant but can't speak it
- **Challenge** 1/4 (50 XP)

Fire Giant's Whispers. The worker hears commands in Giant and feels compelled to obey. They have disadvantage on Wisdom saving throws against enchantment effects.

Heat Tolerance. The worker can work in extreme heat without penalty and has resistance to fire damage.

Actions *Smith's Hammer.* *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

Molten Metal Splash (Recharge 5-6). The worker throws molten metal in a 10-foot cone. Each creature in the area must make a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw, taking 7 (2d6) fire damage on a failed save, or half as much on a successful one.

Encounter: 2-4 Corrupted Workers **Tactics:** Fight desperately but can be reasoned with or incapacitated **Resolution:** Can be cured with *lesser restoration* or by removing the source of corruption

Social Challenges

The Strike Negotiation *Complex social encounter involving multiple factions with conflicting interests*

Participants:

- **Worker Representatives:** Elena Steelheart, Old Henrik
- **Guild Officials:** Guildmaster Thorne, Master Helena
- **City Authorities:** Captain Steelwatch

- **The Party:** As mediators or advocates

Challenge: Each faction has non-negotiable demands and acceptable compromises

Skills Required: Persuasion, Insight, Deception, Intimidation **Complications:** Hidden information, personal grudges, external pressures **Success Conditions:** Find solutions that address core concerns of each faction **Failure Consequences:** Violence erupts, martial law declared, or investigations become impossible

Sample Negotiation Points:

- **Worker Safety:** Improved conditions vs. economic constraints
 - **Missing Workers:** Investigation vs. guild reputation
 - **Union Recognition:** Worker rights vs. management authority
 - **Economic Stability:** Continued production vs. fair treatment
-

Guildmaster's Confession *High-stakes conversation where Thorne reveals the truth about the fire giant pact*

Challenge Rating: 3 (700 XP equivalent) **Required Approach:** Must have significant evidence and choose the right emotional appeals **Skills Used:** Insight (to read his reactions), Persuasion (to encourage honesty), Intimidation (to pressure him) **Key Points:**

- Thorne's genuine regret about the arrangement
- His fear of fire giant retaliation if the pact is broken
- The economic dependence the city has developed
- His knowledge of similar arrangements in other cities

Success: Thorne becomes an ally and provides crucial information **Failure:** Thorne clams up or attempts to have the party eliminated

Treasure and Rewards

Monetary Rewards

- **Worker's Collection:** 150 gp gathered by grateful workers
- **Guild Payment:** 200 gp for "investigating the disturbances" (if working with guild)

- **Recovered Goods:** 300 gp worth of stolen materials and equipment
- **Regional Bounty:** 500 gp reward from regional authorities for exposing the conspiracy

Magic Items Found

Forgemaster's Hammer *Weapon (warhammer), uncommon* A masterwork hammer enhanced with fire giant techniques.

- **Property:** +1 to attack and damage rolls
- **Fire Resistance:** The wielder has resistance to fire damage
- **Heated Strike:** Once per day, the next successful attack deals an additional 1d6 fire damage
- **Masterwork:** Grants advantage on Smithing checks

Cloak of the Coal Walker *Wondrous item, uncommon* A heavy cloak designed to protect workers in dangerous forge conditions.

- **Property:** Advantage on Constitution saving throws against extreme heat
- **Smoke Sight:** Can see normally through smoke and steam
- **Fire Resistance:** Resistance to fire damage for 1 minute (1/day)
- **Worker's Solidarity:** Grants advantage on Charisma checks with laborers and craftspeople

Ring of Giant Speech *Ring, rare* Allows the wearer to understand and speak Giant language.

- **Property:** Understand and speak Giant
- **Giant's Authority:** Once per day, can cast *command* with a save DC of 15, but only affects creatures that understand Giant
- **Detect Giants:** Can sense the presence of giants within 1 mile (no direction or exact location)

Boots of the Foundry Floor *Wondrous item, uncommon* Sturdy boots designed for working in dangerous industrial environments.

- **Property:** Immunity to damage from walking on hot surfaces
- **Sure Footing:** Advantage on Dexterity saving throws to avoid falling

- **Noise Dampening:** Advantage on Stealth checks when moving slowly
- **Industrial Navigation:** Can move through difficult terrain caused by machinery or debris without penalty

Experience and Story Rewards

Investigation Milestones:

- Discovering the pattern of disappearances: 200 XP per character
- Uncovering evidence of the fire giant connection: 400 XP per character
- Successfully infiltrating the deep forges: 300 XP per character
- Exposing the guild conspiracy: 500 XP per character

Social Achievements:

- Gaining the trust of the workers' movement: 150 XP per character
- Successfully mediating between factions: 250 XP per character
- Preventing large-scale violence during the strike: 300 XP per character
- Converting guild members to allies: 200 XP per character

Combat and Danger:

- Standard XP for combat encounters as listed
- Surviving the portal chamber: 400 XP per character
- Rescuing kidnapped workers: 100 XP per character per worker saved

Long-term Benefits

Allies for Future Adventures:

- **Elena Steelheart:** Leader of reformed worker's union, provides information network
- **Captain Steelwatch:** City guard captain, offers official backing and resources
- **Sara Brightforge:** Artificer ally, provides magical item creation and enhancement
- **Reformed Guild Members:** Access to advanced smithing techniques and equipment

Regional Reputation:

- **Hero of the Workers:** Respected by laboring classes throughout the region

- **Guild Reformer:** Known for exposing corruption and protecting the innocent
 - **Giant Hunter:** Reputation for dealing with extraplanar threats
 - **Peacemaker:** Skilled at resolving conflicts between factions
-

Campaign Connections

Setting Up Part 2: "Flames of Conspiracy"

The Larger Threat: Thorne's revelations about other cities with similar arrangements sets up the next adventure. The party learns that:

- At least four other major cities have made pacts with different fire giant clans
- These arrangements are part of a coordinated plan spanning decades
- Political figures at the highest levels may be involved
- The fire giants are preparing for something much larger than individual city exploitation

Key Information for Next Adventure:

- **Names of Compromised Cities:** Steelhold, Hammerfall, Goldenvale, and Ironspire
- **Political Connections:** Hints that regional lords or even royal advisors may be complicit
- **Timeline Acceleration:** The fire giants are moving faster than originally planned
- **Coordinated Response:** The need to organize resistance across multiple cities

Character Development:

- Party members should be level 4 by the end of this adventure
- Relationships established here will carry forward
- Reputation and resources gained provide advantages in political situations
- Knowledge of fire giant tactics and magic becomes crucial

Foreshadowing Future Events

Signs of the Greater Conspiracy:

- References to "the Great Forging" in recovered fire giant communications

- Mention of ancient giant strongholds being prepared for occupation
- Hints about magical artifacts being collected from multiple cities
- Suggestions that the surface world is being prepared for "the new order"

Political Intrigue Elements:

- Regional authorities seem surprisingly well-informed about "isolated incidents"
 - Some officials dismiss the fire giant threat too quickly
 - Trade routes and military movements show suspicious patterns
 - Diplomatic messages between cities have increased dramatically
-

Appendices

Appendix A: Scaling for Different Levels

For 1st Level Parties:

- Reduce combat encounters by one enemy each
- Lower DCs by 2 for most challenges
- Provide more obvious clues and NPC guidance
- Focus heavily on investigation over combat

For 4th Level Parties:

- Add additional enemies to encounters
- Include more fire giant agents and magical effects
- Raise investigation DCs by 1-2
- Add time pressure and resource management challenges

Appendix B: Alternative Campaign Themes

Economic Focus: Emphasize the industrial revolution themes and worker's rights

Political Focus: Highlight corruption and conspiracy at governmental levels

Magical Focus: Concentrate on planar threats and supernatural elements

Combat Focus: Include more direct confrontations with fire giant agents

Appendix C: City Generator

For creating additional compromised cities in future adventures:

Industrial Specialization:

- Weapons manufacturing (like Ironhaven)
- Armor and defensive equipment
- Magical item creation
- Siege engine construction
- Mining and raw material extraction

Fire Giant Clans:

- Different clans have different priorities and methods
- Some focus on military equipment, others on magical items
- Clan rivalries can be exploited by clever parties
- Each clan has distinctive runic markings and techniques

Appendix D: Running the Strike

Day-by-Day Events:

- **Day 1:** Peaceful demonstrations, information gathering opportunities
- **Day 2:** Tensions rise, guild brings in mercenaries, more radical elements emerge
- **Day 3:** First violence, authorities threaten martial law, party must choose sides
- **Day 4:** Crisis point, party's actions determine whether violence escalates

Managing Multiple Factions:

- Track reputation with each group separately
- Allow for shifting alliances based on party actions
- Provide opportunities for creative solutions beyond pure combat
- Remember that most NPCs want to avoid bloodshed if possible

Designer's Notes

This adventure serves as the foundation for the larger Forge Wars campaign while being complete and satisfying on its own. The industrial setting provides a change of pace from typical fantasy environments while maintaining classic D&D elements.

The focus on social conflict and investigation gives characters opportunities to develop their non-combat skills while building toward the epic confrontations of later adventures. The fire giant threat is established as both immediate and long-term, providing clear motivation for continued adventures.

The worker's rights theme adds moral complexity and real-world relevance while avoiding heavy-handed messaging. Players can engage with these themes as much or as little as they prefer while still having a compelling adventure.

Estimated Play Time: 5-6 sessions of 4-5 hours each **Party Composition:** Benefits from diverse skills, particularly social and investigation abilities **Difficulty:** Moderate, with emphasis on roleplay and problem-solving over combat optimization

End of Part 1 - Continue with "The Forge Wars: Flames of Conspiracy (2 of 3)" for the next chapter of this epic campaign